

Zihang Li — Curriculum Vitae

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*Ph.D. Candidate (ABD), Applied Economics • On the 2026–2027
job market • Available August 2027*

Education

Auburn University

Ph.D. in Applied Economics

All But Dissertation (ABD); coursework and comprehensive examinations completed; dissertation defense planned for July 2027

Auburn, AL

Aug. 2021–July 2027 (expected)

Auburn University

M.S. in Applied Economics

Auburn, AL

Aug. 2021–May 2025

Konkuk University

M.A. in Economics

Seoul, South Korea

Aug. 2018–Feb. 2021

Harbin University of Science and Technology

B.M. in Accounting

Harbin, China

Aug. 2014–Aug. 2018

Specialization

Health Economics; Industrial Organization; Applied Microeconomics

Teaching Interests

Undergraduate: Principles of Microeconomics; Principles of Macroeconomics; Econometrics; Business Statistics; Data Analytics; Industrial Organization; Health Economics; Big Data Analysis

Graduate: Applied Microeconometrics; Econometrics; Health Economics; Business Statistics; Industrial Organization; Risk Analysis

Teaching Experience

Auburn University

Independent Instructor

Auburn, AL

2023–present

- ECON 2020: Principles of Microeconomics (Fall 2023; Spring 2025; Summer 2026)
 - Teaching evaluations improved from 4.37/6.0 to 5.33/6.0 (Spring 2025) and 5.30/6.0 (Summer 2026)
- ECON 2030: Principles of Macroeconomics (Spring 2024; Spring 2026)
 - Teaching evaluation: 5.21/6.0
- Full course responsibility: curriculum design, syllabus development, assessment, and grading

Auburn University*Module Instructor***Auburn, AL***2025–present*

○ ECON 5700/6700: Health Economics (Spring 2025)

- Led instruction on Demand and Supply of Health Insurance and Organization of the Health Care Market for undergraduate and graduate sections
- Led session on data and statistical methods, including empirical applications in health economics

Auburn University*Teaching Assistant***Auburn, AL***2021–present*

○ ECON 2020: Principles of Microeconomics (Fall 2021; Spring 2022; Fall 2022; Summer 2025)

○ ECON 2030: Principles of Macroeconomics (Fall 2021; Spring 2022; Fall 2022)

○ ECON 4600: Econometrics (Fall 2024; Fall 2025)

- TA evaluation improved from 5.39/6.0 (Fall 2024) to 5.86/6.0 (Fall 2025)
- Hold independent recitation sessions weekly, teaching R programming, regression analysis, and quantitative methods applicable to economics and financial econometrics
- Individually guide each student through the research process: formulating research questions, identifying datasets, choosing research designs, implementing data work, and debugging code

Konkuk University*Teaching Assistant***Seoul, South Korea***2018–2020*

○ Assisted with Environmental Economics, Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, and History of Economic Thought

○ Prepared course materials and graded assignments for 200+ students

Working Papers

“Psychiatric Medication Use at the Medicaid Eligibility Threshold in States with Separate CHIP”*Job Market Paper; under review at Health Economics.*

Local-linear regression discontinuities using the 2016–2019, 2021–2022, and 2024 National Survey of Children's Health for children ages 6–17 in separate-CHIP states; estimated psychiatric-medication use is 9.7 percentage points higher just above the Medicaid threshold before the pandemic, 16.9 points higher during the federal enrollment freeze, and 7.5 points higher in 2024. This overlooked within-public-insurance cutoff preserves public eligibility on both sides even though coverage terms can change. The paper is the first to use the Medicaid-to-separate-CHIP boundary to study children's psychiatric-medication use across three federal enrollment regimes, shifting attention from insurance status to continuity in behavioral-health care. Software: Stata 18.

“Market Authorization Holder (MAH) Pilot Program and Innovation Investment in China's Pharmaceutical Industry”*First and corresponding author; with Tannista Banerjee, Aditi Sengupta, and Shan He; preparing for submission to International Journal of Industrial Organization.*

Difference-in-differences, triple-difference, and Poisson DID on Chinese pharmaceutical patent data (2015–2021); identifies positive effects of the 2016 MAH deregulation on patent authorizations, backward citations, and patent claims for non-Traditional Chinese Medicine companies, with no significant effects for TCM firms. By studying a reform that separated drug marketing rights from manufacturing, the paper contributes evidence on how regulatory design shapes heterogeneous innovation responses in an emerging pharmaceutical market.

“Strategic Patent Listing and Generic Challenge in China’s Drug Patent-Linkage Register”

Sole-authored working paper.

Using a complete, dated census of China’s patent-linkage register from its 2021 launch, documents quality-selective listing and a thin compound-patent backbone: listed chemical patents have 3.7 times the family citations of comparable unlisted patents, while 45 percent of listed chemical products lack a live compound patent. Generic challenges arrive about ten months after listing and disproportionately target compound-free products and foreign originators.

“Adverse Childhood Experiences and Co-occurring Physical–Mental Health Conditions in U.S. Children: Evidence from the National Survey of Children’s Health”

With Sanket Kanekar; preparing for submission to Nature Mental Health.

Survey-weighted multinomial logistic regressions on the 2022–2024 NSCH classify children into no-condition, physical-only, mental-only, and co-occurring categories. At 4+ ACEs, the co-occurring RRR reaches 9.77 versus 7.43 for mental-only and 1.90 for physical-only; positive RERI at every ACE level indicates super-additive risk beyond independent physical and mental pathways. Financial hardship and household mental illness most strongly predict the co-occurring profile, with results robust across alternative outcome definitions, ACE specifications, and demographic subgroups. Software: Stata 18.

Work in Progress

“Food Deserts and Health Outcomes: Evidence from HCUP, 2012–2022” with Ruchika Rungta

“Classifying Product versus Process Innovation in Chinese Pharmaceutical and Medical Device Patents: A Novel PatentBERT–LLM Methodology”

“Hiring at the Floor: The H-1B Program and the Wages of Foreign-Born Allied-Health Workers” with Sanket Kanekar

“Rationing by Lottery and the Economics of Gaming: Multiple Registration in the H-1B Visa Program, FY2021–FY2024” with Sanket Kanekar

Grant Experience

Submitted; not funded — reviewers encouraged resubmission

NSF HBCU-EiR

Oct. 2025

- **Status:** Reviewers rated the proposal favorably and encouraged a revise-and-resubmit; the team is now revising the project for submission to NIH/NIMH
- **Solicitation:** NSF 23-598 (HBCU-EiR)
- **Proposal ID:** 2602827
- **Proposal Title:** Economic Evaluation of AI-Powered Virtual Reality Wellness Platforms: Enhancing Accessibility, Engagement, and Cost-Effectiveness in Mental Health Support
- **PI:** Dr. Sanket Kanekar [Alabama State University]
- **Co-PIs:** Dr. Kimberly B. Garza [Auburn University]; Dr. Travis C. Evans [Auburn University]
- **Role:** Other Authorized User (Research.gov); Graduate Research Lead (internal)
- **Selected contributions:**
 - Led proposal writing, budget development (\$1,261,433), and grant administration coordination
 - Co-developed the randomized controlled trial (RCT) study design and implementation plan
 - Co-designed and led components of the economic evaluation plan (cost-effectiveness and budget impact analyses)
 - Independently built the minimum viable product to support the submission, including the VR environment and the AI (LLM) training pipeline

Service and Administration

Summer 2026: Course (Re)Design Program, Biggio Center, Auburn University

2025: Grant coordination and budget planning, NSF HBCU-EiR proposal with Alabama State University (\$1.26M)

2024–present: Independent recitation instructor and student research mentor, ECON 4600 Econometrics, Auburn University

Summer 2024: Course (Re)Design Program, Biggio Center, Auburn University

2023–present: Curriculum development and course coordination, ECON 2020/2030, Auburn University

Fall 2019: Graduate Mentor, Research for Undergraduate Study (RUS), Konkuk University

Conference and Seminar Experience

Nov. 2026: Presenter, Southern Economic Association Meeting, Houston, TX

July. 2026: Attendee, Alabama Higher Education AI Exchange: Classroom to Career, Auburn University, Auburn, AL

July. 2026: Presenter, Western Economic Association International Meeting, Denver, CO

June. 2026: Presenter, American Society of Health Economists (ASHEcon) Conference, Minneapolis, MN

Mar. 2026: Attendee, ACS-CAN Cancer Research Symposium, Montgomery, AL

Mar. 2026: Attendee, Montgomery.AI, Montgomery, AL

Nov. 2025: Presenter, Southern Economic Association Meeting, Tampa, FL

Oct. 2025: Contestant, Magic City Classic Business Pitch Competition, Birmingham, AL

June. 2025: Presenter, Western Economic Association International Meeting, San Francisco, CA

May. 2025: Attendee, XR Summit 2025, Auburn, AL

Nov. 2024: Presenter, Southern Economic Association Meeting, Washington, DC

Oct. 2024: Presenter, Three-Minute Thesis (3MT), Auburn, AL

Sept. 2024: Presenter, Outreach and Engaged Scholarship Symposium, Auburn, AL

Nov. 2023: Attendee, Southern Economic Association Meeting, New Orleans, LA

Grants, Honors, and Awards

Aug. 2021–present: Graduate Fellowship, Department of Economics, Auburn University

Aug. 2018–Feb. 2021: Graduate Tuition Scholarship, Konkuk University

July. 2019–Dec. 2019: Research for Undergraduate Study (RUS) Grant, Konkuk University

Professional Memberships

American Economic Association (AEA)

Southern Economic Association (SEA)

Western Economic Association International (WEAI)

American Society of Health Economists (ASHEcon)

Auburn University Health Economics Research Group (AUHERG) [\[link\]](#)

Auburn University Extended Reality Faculty Learning Community (XR FLC)

Skills

Software: R; Stata; Python; L^AT_EX; GAUSS (basic); MATLAB (basic); EViews (basic); JMulTi (basic); Blender (basic); QGIS (basic)

Languages: Korean (native); Chinese (native); English (fluent)

Dissertation Committee

Chair: Tannista Banerjee, Professor of Economics, Auburn University

Members: Hyeongwoo Kim, Patrick E. Molony Professor of Economics, Auburn University
Aditi Sengupta, Associate Professor of Economics, Auburn University

University Reader: Kimberly B. Garza, Associate Professor of Health Outcomes Research and Policy, Harrison College of Pharmacy, Auburn University

Professional References

Tannista Banerjee (*Dissertation Chair*)

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Hyeongwoo Kim (*Committee Member*)

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Peng Shao (*Teaching Reference*)

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Letters of recommendation available upon request. Last updated: September 2026.